PERSONAL, PROFESSIONAL AND SOCIAL ETHICS

Ethics means the rules and principles regulating the behaviour of individuals. It is the study of what is right or wrong in human conduct. Ethics states the dos and don’ts in a specific setting.

Personal, Professional, and Social ethics involve individual values, workplace conduct, and societal norms, respectively, all influencing how we interact and make decisions in various contexts.

PERSONAL ETHICS

Personal ethics are ethical principles that a person uses when making decisions and behaving in both personal and professional settings. These ethics influence various aspects of a person's life and help individuals develop their work ethic, personal and professional goals, and values. Individuals use their ethics to determine between right and wrong and influence how someone behaves in challenging situations. Each person's code of ethics varies, but many people share common ethics such as honesty and respect these principles aren't set in stone but evolve through one's experiences, upbringing, cultural influences, and personal reflections.

Key aspects of Personal Ethics-

1. **Internal vs. external:** Unlike professional ethics, which often come from external codes of conduct, personal ethics are self-driven and internalized. They're not explicitly written down but guide your actions from within.

2. **Uniqueness:** While common ethical principles like honesty, kindness, and fairness often play a role, everyone's personal ethics are unique. Their relative importance and how they apply in specific situations can vary greatly.

3. **Decision-making:** When faced with choices, your personal ethics act as a framework for weighing options and making decisions you feel are right and aligned with your values.

4. **Impact on behavior:** From everyday interactions like telling the truth or being helpful to tackling more complex moral dilemmas, your personal ethics influence how you act and treat others.

PROFESSIONAL ETHICS

Professional people and those working in acknowledged professions exercise specialist knowledge and skill. How the use of this knowledge should be governed when providing a service to the public can be considered a moral issue and is termed professional ethics. Professionals are capable of making judgments, applying their skills and reaching informed decisions in situations that the general public cannot, because they have not received the relevant training. One of the earliest examples of professional ethics is probably the Hippocratic oath to which medical doctors still adhere to this day.

Professional ethics is a set of standards adopted by a professional community. Professional ethics are regulated by standards, which are often referred to as codes of ethics.

The code of ethics is very important because it gives us boundaries that we have to stay within in our professional careers. The one problem with the code of ethics is that we can't always have the answers black and white. Sometimes there are grey areas where the answers aren't so simple. Professional ethics are also known as **Ethical Business Practices**.

A number of professional organisations define their ethical approach as a number of discrete components. Typically these include:

Integrity

Integrity is a concept of consistency of actions, values, methods, measures, principles, expectations, and outcomes. In ethics, integrity is regarded as the honesty and truthfulness or accuracy of one's actions. Integrity can be regarded as the opposite of hypocrisy, in that integrity regards internal consistency as a virtue, and suggests that parties holding apparently conflicting values should account for the discrepancy or alter their beliefs.

Transparency

Transparency, as used in science, engineering, business, the humanities and in a social context more generally, implies openness, communication, and accountability. Transparency is operating in such a way that it is easy for others to see what actions are performed. For example, a cashier making change at a point of sale by segregating a customer's large bills, counting up from the sale amount, and placing the change on the counter in such a way as to invite the customer to verify the amount of change demonstrates transparency

Accountability

In ethics and governance, accountability is answerability, blameworthiness, liability, and the expectation of account-giving. As an aspect of governance, it has been central to discussions related to problems in the public sector, nonprofit and private (corporate) worlds. In leadership roles, accountability is the acknowledgment and assumption of responsibility for actions, products, decisions, and policies including the administration, governance, and implementation within the scope of the role or employment position and encompassing the obligation to report, explain and be answerable for resulting consequences.

Confidentiality

Confidentiality is a set of rules or a promise that limits access or places restrictions on certain types of information. Confidentiality is ensuring that information is accessible only to those authorized to have access.

Objectivity

Law is a system of rules and guidelines which are enforced through social institutions to govern behavior. Laws are made by governments, specifically by their legislatures. The formation of laws themselves may be influenced by a constitution (written or unwritten) and the rights encoded therein. The law shapes politics, economics and society in countless ways and serves as a social mediator of relations between people.

Respectfulness

Respect gives a positive feeling of esteem or deference for a person or other entity (such as a nation or a religion), and also specific actions and conduct representative of that esteem. Respect can be a specific feeling of regard for the actual qualities of the one respected (e.g., "I have great respect for her judgment"). It can also be conduct in accord with a specific ethic of respect. Rude conduct is usually considered to indicate a lack of respect, *disrespect*, where as actions that honor somebody or something indicate respect. Specific ethics of respect are of fundamental importance to various cultures and therefore key to success in any organization is Respectfulness.

Honesty

"Honesty is the best policy" is a famous statement. Honesty refers to a facet of moral character and connotes positive and virtuous attributes such as integrity, truthfulness and straightforwardness along with the absence of lying, cheating or theft. Honesty is revered in many cultures and religions.

Obedience to the law

Law is a system of rules and guidelines which are enforced through social institutions to govern behavior. Laws are made by governments, specifically by their legislatures and in organizations, by the Top Management.. The formation of laws themselves may be influenced by a constitution (written or unwritten) and the rights encoded therein. The law shapes politics, economics and society in countless ways and serves as a social mediator of relations between people. And the employees working in an organization are bound to obey the Laws & Regulations of that organization.

PERSONAL AND PROFESSIONAL ETHICS

Personal Ethics	Professional Ethics
Personal ethics refers to the sense of rights and wrongs of a person.	Professional ethics refers to the strict **code of conduct** and guidelines that are imposed on employees within the industrial setting.
Learned from **family, friends and relatives since childhood.**	Learned when **one becomes part of corporate world.**
They relate to your **deep-rooted principles,** and how religiously you follow them determines the kind of person you are.	How well you **follow the protocol** of the company is what will matter here.

Personal Ethics	Professional Ethics
An individual has the **choice of changing** his personal ethics.	An individual **does not have the choice** of changing his professional ethics.
The **accountability is on the individual** alone.	The accountability is not only on the individual but **also the organization** as well.
Non-compliance with them causes **mental disharmony and personal dilemma.**	**Non-compliance** to such rules may **risk your reputation,** as your behavior will immediately be reported as unprofessional.
Example: Openness, Honesty, Friendliness, Respect for Others, Loyalty, Fairness, Integrity.	**Example:** Abiding by the law, Industry Standards, Worker Treatment, Confidentiality, Worker Safety.

SOCIAL ETHICS

Social ethics refers to the principles and values that guide individuals and societies in making decisions that promote harmonious coexistence and well-being among people. It involves making ethical choices that prioritize the common good and respect for human dignity while considering the impact of these choices on society as a whole. Social ethics emphasises the importance of fairness, justice, and compassion in interpersonal relationships and social structures.

It shapes laws, policies and cultural norms and maintains justice, fairness and responsibility.

Examples- Environmental Ethics, Human Rights, and Gender equality.

Components of Social Ethics:

1. Universality

Social ethics are based on universal principles of justice and equity that apply to all people, regardless of their origin, gender, sexual orientation, religion or any other characteristic. This approach seeks to ensure that all individuals are treated with equality and respect.

2. Solidarity

Solidarity is a fundamental value in social ethics, since it promotes collaboration and mutual support between members of society. Solidarity implies being willing to help others in times of need and to work together to achieve common goals for the benefit of all.

3. Social Justice

Social justice is one of the pillars of social ethics, since it seeks to guarantee that all people have equal access to opportunities and resources. Social justice involves combating discrimination, inequality and exclusion, to build a more inclusive and fair society for all.

4. Empathy

Empathy is the ability to put yourself in the shoes of others and understand their feelings and perspectives. In social ethics, empathy plays a crucial role in developing healthy relationships and creating a climate of mutual understanding and respect between people.